



Internship Report

Prediction of RNA 3D structure using gradient-descending and
knowledge-based scoring function

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Abstract

Write an abstract here.

Key words: financial models, machine learning...

Contents

1	Presentation of the company	1
2	Preliminary notions	1
2.1	Central Dogma	1
2.2	RNA molecule	2
2.3	RNA secondary structure	2
2.4	RNA tertiary structure	3
3	Introduction	4
4	Data and Dataset	5
4.1	PDB database	5
4.2	PDB file structure	5
4.3	Difference between PDB file and mmCIF file	6
5	Materials and Methods	7
5.1	Knowledge based potential	7
5.2	Objective function	7
5.3	Optimization algorithm	8
5.3.1	Local exploration	8
5.3.2	Global exploration	9
5.4	Complete Pipeline	9
5.5	Different Applications	9
6	Results	12
6.1	Interpolation results	12
6.2	Comparaison between original and predicted structures	12
6.3	Comparatives tables	12
6.4	Line chart of score function for folding trajectory	12
6.5	Internet platform for RNA folding	12
7	Discussion and Perspectives	13
8	Conclusion	14
	Glossary	15
	References	16
	Websites	17
	List of figures	18
	List of tables	18

1 Presentation of the company

2 Preliminary notions

The goal of this chapter is to give insights on preliminary notions that are important to comprehend my report.

2.1 Central Dogma

Every cells of every living being, excluding virus and a few exceptions, has **DesoxyriboNucleic Acid (DNA)**. This molecule contains the genetic information. It holds all information for an organism. However the DNA alone cannot do anything, it needs to be express in proteins. This process is called the central dogma of molecular biology [7]. For that, the cell perform two steps :

1. Transcription : This steps copy a part of DNA and transcribes it into a intermediate molecule called **RiboNucleic Acid (RNA)**, or more precisely messenger RNA (mRNA). The transcription is performed inside the nucleus.
2. Translation : The RNA obtained in the previous step are now used to make a protein. The translation is performed outside of the nucleus.

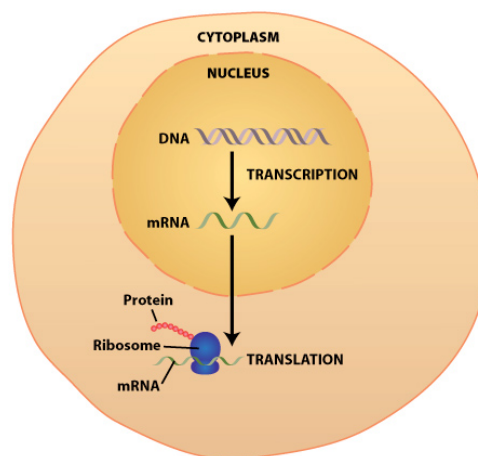


Figure 1: A diagram illustrating the processes of DNA transcription into RNA and RNA translation into proteins. Source : [1]

Recently, researchers have discovered that RNA serves more than just an intermediate role. Indeed, many RNAs, known as non-coding RNAs, are never translated into proteins. Instead, they have a regulation role inside the cell.

2.2 RNA molecule

The RNA is single-stranded, unlike DNA which is double-stranded, and it's a polymer of nucleotids. The linear arrangement of these nucleotids defines it's primary structure (1D structure) or it's raw sequence. A nucleotide is composed by three components (Fig. 2) : a nucleobase, a ribose sugar and a phosphate group. Unlike phosphate group and ribose sugar who is common for all nucleotids, the nucleobase determine the type of nucleotide. For the RNA, there are four types of nucleobases : Guanine (G), Adenine (A), Cytosine (C) and Uracil (U).

Structure of RNA

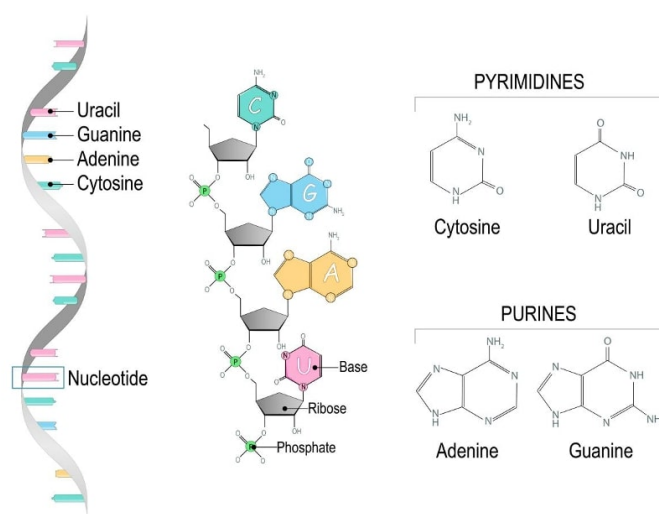


Figure 2: A diagram illustrating the 1D-structure of RNA and nucleotid composition. Source : [3]

There is two form of nucleobase : pyrimidines for uracil and cytosine, purines for adenine and guanine. Purines have a second ring, so they have more atoms and are bigger than pyrimidines. These nucleobase can assemble by stacking on top of each other trough van der Waals interactions. There is also structural constraint influences by ribose sugar chain, this chain is called the backbone [15]. And finally, the phosphate group, carry negative energy so to neutralize this charges, RNA needs heteroatoms like ions or ligand to regulate it's energy. So the conformation of RNA it's very dependant of the environnement condition, it's surrounding solvant and ions has a strong influences on it's stability and it's folding [9].

2.3 RNA secondary structure

The secondary or 2D structure is dictated by the primary structure. The 2D structure define the canonical interactions, such as Watson-Crick base pairing (A paring with U and G paring with C) and Wobble pair (G with U). The secondary structure alone can't define the folding of a RNA. Indeed, many pair can give multiple possible arrangement in 3D space (see Fig. 3). 2D structure can also be driven by the RNA functions and interactions with proteins or other molecules. Like for 1D structure, the secondary structure influence completely the 3D structure, so knowing the RNA secondary structure for make a prediction can be effective and having a better accuracy.

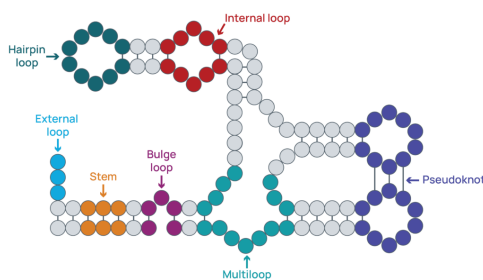


Figure 3: A diagram illustrating different structural motifs . Source : [10]

2.4 RNA tertiary structure

The transition from the secondary structure to the tertiary structure, or 3D structure, is determined by the geometric and topological properties of the motifs formed in the previous step. These motifs such as loops or bulges act as flexible hinges and anchor points.

Thanks to the flexibility of these nodes, the strand continues to fold. Long-range interactions then arise between 2D motifs that may be very far apart along the 1D structure but are geometrically close to one another in space. For example, a loop located at one end may interlock with the cavity of another region.

It is this dense network of interactions between the different motifs that forces the RNA to fold in a highly specific manner to adopt its final three-dimensional structure. In biology, a fundamental principle dictates that structure determines function. The tertiary structure allow the RNA molecule to interact with other element from the cell.

So to know the folding and the function of a RNA we need to know the 1D structure (4a). This will be used to determine the secondary structure (4b), to finally predict the 3D structure (4c).

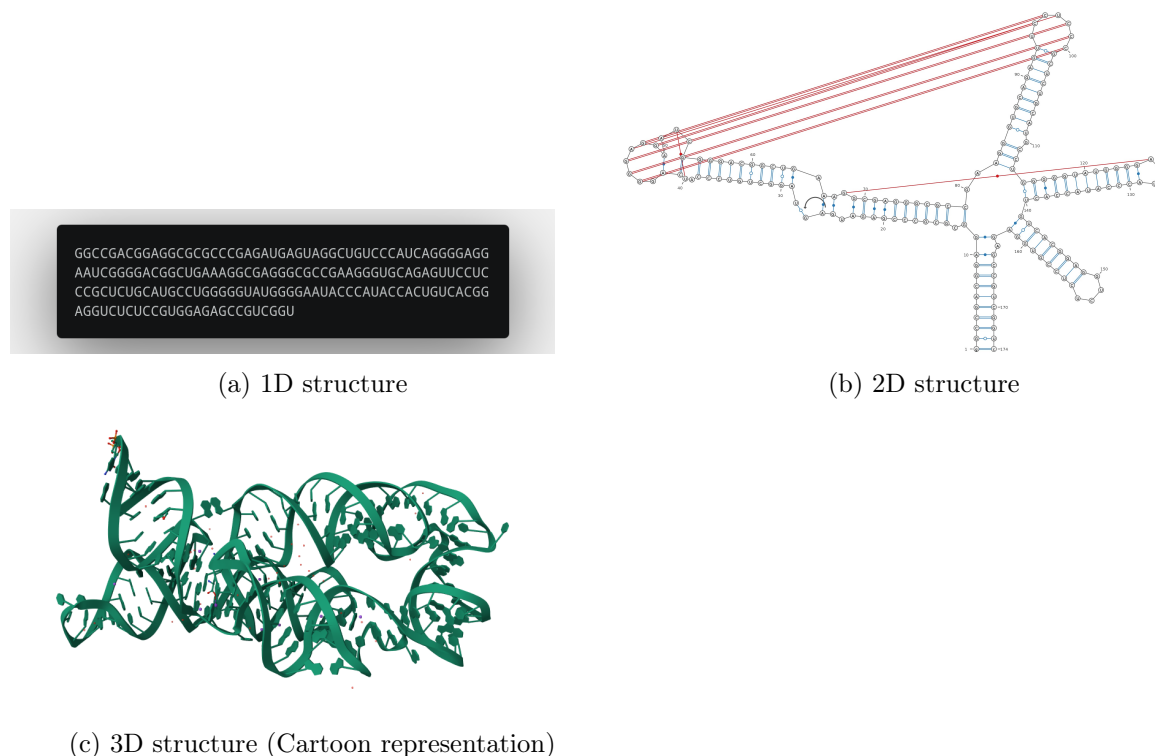


Figure 4: The three different level of representation for the same RNA (PDB ID : 3DIQ)

3 Introduction

4 Data and Dataset

4.1 PDB database

The **Protein Data Bank (PDB)** [2, 4] is the principal worldwide archive for three-dimensional structures of biological macromolecule such as proteins and nucleic acids. This database centralize all structure determined by experimental methods such as X-ray crystallography, nuclear magnetic resonance spectroscopy and cryo-electron microscopy. It can be accessed through its website and an API. Each structure has an identifier composed of four letters or numbers (e.g. 1J8G) and they can be download in two format : PDB file and **macromolecular Crystallographic Information File (mmCIF)** files. A format change happen in 2014, with the advent of cryo-electron microscopy, researchers had the tools to see larger molecules like RNA polymerase. These types of molecules have a lot of atoms but PDB file are restricted to only 99 999 atoms, with mmCIF files, there is no limit on the molecule's scale. As a result, every new molecule added to the database is now in this format. These two format will be describe in the next section.

4.2 PDB file structure

The PDB file is a file to represent each atom from a molecule, especially for protein and RNA. Each line have a keywords to explicite the line content. The file can be split in 3 parts.

The first one contains header and metadata. This part have all information about the molecule and the experimentation.

Keywords	Description
HEADER	Molecule Type, PDB Id, deposition date
TITLE	Title of the experiment
COMPND	Description of the molecule compenent
SOURCE	Biological origin or Synthetic
KEYWDS	Descriptive keywords for the structure
EXPDTA	Experimental Methods
AUTHOR	Author of the deposit
REVDAT	Revision history
JRNL	Publication reference
REMARK	Comments numbered from most important to least important

Table 1: All keywords founded in a first part of a PDB files

The table 1 present all keywords and his signification. REMARK contains useful information such as the resolution of the molecule. The resolution is the difference between the atoms found experimentally and the actual atoms. More the resolution is low, more the experimental molecules can be accurate.

The second part are about the sequence and the crystallography parameters. These keywords are all in the table 2

Keywords	Description
SEQRES	Primary Sequence by chain
CRYST1	Crystal lattice parameters
SCAL1/2/3	Orthogonal coordinate conversion matrices

Table 2: All keywords founded in a second part of a PDB files

A chain in an alternative conformation for the same molecule, sometimes by adding some ligand or other molecules to induce the change of conformation. SEQRES can be used to find

the acid nucleics sequence that can be retrieved and put inside a algorithm to predict the three-dimensional structure.

The last part is the goal of this file, the coordinates of every atoms from the molecule. This section is formatted in fixed columns. It's not just generic space between columns, the position is important. The information for every line is resume in the table 3.

```
ATOM      1  05'   U  A   1       12.967  20.885  19.962  1.00  5.19           0
```

Figure 5: Line 808 from the pdb file from the pdb id 1J8G [8]

Columns	Fields	Value (from Fig. 5)	Description
1-6	Record Name	ATOM	Two types: ATOM for standard residues and HETATM for heteroatoms
7-11	Serial Number	1	Sequential atom number
13-16	Atom Name	05'	Atom name per IUPAC nomenclature
17	AltLoc	blank	Alternate location indicator, used when an atom has more than one modeled conformation (A/B)
18-20	Residue Name	U	Residue type (e.g. uracil for RNA)
22	Chain ID	A	Chain identifier
23-26	Residue Sequence Number	1	Residue position within the chain
31-38	x	12.967	Cartesian X coordinate (Å)
39-46	y	20.885	Cartesian Y coordinate (Å)
47-54	z	19.962	Cartesian Z coordinate (Å)
55-60	Occupancy	1.00	Fraction of the unit cell in which this atom occupies this position (1.00 = always present)
61-66	Temperature Factor	5.19	Thermal displacement / positional uncertainty (B-factor); lower = sharper, more ordered atom
77-78	Element	0	Chemical element symbol

Table 3: All keywords found in the coordinate section of a PDB file

4.3 Difference between PDB file and mmCIF file

PDB files and mmCIF files have the same goal: describe the structural content. They have the same type of information, coordinates, experimental metadata. For the same PDB id, these two files must describe exactly the same molecule. The difference between them is not about the information but about the structure file.

A PDB file uses fixed-width columns, so a parser needs to know exactly the specification. On the contrary, mmCIF is a key-value format, where each value is explicitly named. This format is more general and can be used by more tools and more easily. Because each value is a free token instead of a fixed-width column, mmCIF has no limit on chain ID length or residue number, which is why it can scale to every molecule, even massive assemblies like ribosomes or cryo-EM structures that a PDB file cannot represent. On the other hand, a mmCIF file is less user-friendly when you want to read information without a parser. These differences between these file types explain why both extensions are usually available inside the PDB database, except for very large structures where only mmCIF can be provided.

5 Materials and Methods

5.1 Knowledge based potential

A knowledge based potential or statistical potential is an empirical scoring function. Indeed, it comes from a statistical analysis of 3D structures coming from the PDB. Unlike the physical potential, which is based on fundamental laws of molecular mechanisms, a knowledge based score function is based on the Boltzmann inversion principle. It posits that the frequency with which a given structural feature occurs in nature reflects its free-energy state, a theoretical approach initially formalised for macromolecules in the work of Miyazawa and Jernigan [14] and Sippl [18].

In the case of RNA, the statistical potential compares the special conformation frequency, like interatomic distances or torsion angles, and a reference random distribution. If an interaction is observed significantly more often than randomly, then we attribute a favorable negative energy score, and if the interaction is rare, it has a penalty.

In this internship, we used four different statistical potentials. There are all distance-based potentials, meaning we cannot use them for torsion angles.

- Ribonucleic Acids Statistical Potential (RASP) [5]: It's using a simplified full-atom (23 atoms type) representation and a standard statistical reference.
- Distance-scaled Finite Ideal-gas Reference state (DFIRE-RNA) [21]: It's using a full-atom (85 atoms type) representation and used another representation based on finite ideal gas. This representation eliminates the spatial bias.
- residue-separation-based RNA Statistical Potential (rsRNASP) [20]: Unlike DFIRE-RNA and RASP, it's based on the fact that the RNA folding is hierarchical. Indeed the interaction between neighbour nucleotides do not obey the same geometric constraint as interactions between nucleotides that are further apart in the sequence. So this potential, use the full-atom representation. It calculates distinct energy potentials based on the sequential distance between two atoms.
- coarsened-grained-based RNA Statistical Potential (cgRNASP) [19]: It's using the same approach as rsRNASP but changes the representation using only few atoms, less than 10 atoms, to represent all the nucleotides.

We will use this different statistical potential in the objective function.

5.2 Objective function

The objective function will be used in a gradient descending optimisation. So it's need to be continuous and derivable. But, as we see before a knowledge based potential it's not derivable and continuous. Indeed it's only a matrix with energy depending on the distance and two atoms. So to bypass this problem, we used a Catmull-Rom interpolation. It's a mathematical geometric modeling technique used to create a smooth cubic curve, that passes through the point from the matrix of the potential. The fundamental property of this model lies in the automatic calculation of the tangent at each points P_i , which is defined to be strictly collinear with the vector connecting the adjacent points P_{i-1} and P_{i+1} . Thanks to this property, the curve we obtained is continuous and derivable, and can be used in a gradient descending.

To represent the RNA, we used a bead-springs representation or coarsened-grained representation, that means to represent the nucleotides we used only one atom and every atom are connected by a spring. This representation is more faster than a full-atom representation but less precise.

$$w_1 * \text{Potential Statistical} + w_2 * (k * \sum_{i=1}^{n-1} (l_0 - r)^2) + w_2 * WCA \quad (1)$$

$$WCA = \begin{cases} \epsilon \left[\left(\frac{r_{min}}{r} \right)^{12} - 2 \left(\frac{r_{min}}{r} \right)^6 + 1 \right] & \text{si } r < r_{min} \\ 0 & \text{si } r \geq r_{min} \end{cases} \quad (2)$$

So the objective function (see Equation 1) have three terms. The first one is the statistical potential using the interpolation.

The second one is the Fraenkel potential, it's used to regulate the springs compression and it's a constant so it's doesn't influence the continuous and derivability of the function. Indeed this term, have four constant, the n is the number of nucleotids. Then, the l_0 is equilibrium length, it's where the springs have no force, no energy. Next, the r is the instentaneous distance between two beads. Finally, the k , it's the stiffness constant, defines the diffuculty to compress or stretch the springs.

The last one, it's the Week-Chandler-Anderson (WCA) potential (see Equation 2), this potential is a trunked version of the Lennard-Jones potential [12]. We include this term to avoid steric clash. Indeed this terms is only active when two beads are too close. This function is important because we doesn't influence the knowledge-based potential. To achieve this goal, there are three constant, the r , it's the euclidienne distance between two atoms. Then, the r_{min} , it's the minimal distance where the potential energy is minimal. And the ϵ represent the depth of the energy well of the original potential. The term $+1$ ensures that the energy vanishes continuously at $r = r_{min}$.

Thanks to the interpolation and the others terms, the objective function can ensure that no physical laws are being violated. So the results can be used to other application. Since a present you the objectivefunction, i will now present you my algorithm.

5.3 Optimization algorithm

The goal of the optimization algorithm is to find minimizing the objective function, because a find the most thermodynamically stable structure, the energy must be minimal. So to navigate through the complex energy landscape and find this minimal energy, we combined a local exploration via gradient descent and a global exploration inspired by the bassin-hopping algorithm.

5.3 Local exploration

For the local exploration we used the Adam optimization algorithm [11], unlike the AlphaFold 1, who used the L-BFGS optimization algorithm [13]. In fact, in our case, we start from a linear structure and we try to folding it. But the L-BFGS converge fast to the first local minimum, however a knowledge-based potential have a lot of minimum local due to the interpolation. Also ADAM doesn't make assumptions about curvature, on the contrary the L-BFGS who constructs its approximation of the Hessian based on the history of gradient differences. Therefore, we used the ADAM optimization to resolve our problem.

At each iteration, the algorithm calculates the total energy of the system and performs a backpropagation to obtain the energy gradients with respect to the spatial coordinates of the atoms. These gradients are the physical forces acting on the molecule. We have also add a numerical stability to avoid a explosion of the molecule when we have a steric clash during the foldin, by adding a gradient clapping mechanism, capping the gradient norm at a maximum value.

To not have a endless loop, we have a two security. The first one is a maximum of cycle, and the second one, is a *local patience*. If the energy decrease between steps falls below a minimum tolerance threshold, then we add $+1$ to a counter until the algorithm reach the *local patience*, and stop early the local exploration, at the end we have a phase score.

5.3 Global exploration

As mentioned above, the statistical potential interpolation have a lot of local minima, and a gradient descending alone have tendency to be trapped in a local minima. To overcome this problem, we added a global optimization loop.

When the local exploration has converged, the algorithm compared the phase score with the best historical score. It stores the best conformation, then applies a random geometric perturbation to the 3D coordinates. This noise ejects the structure from it's current local minimum. After that the noisy structure is send to a new local optimization phase. To not lose maybe a good structure, the amplitude of the perturbation decreases over the cycles according to a cooling factor.

The global exploration terminates based on two criteria : either the noise amplitude reach a minimum threshold or the algorithm is no longer able to find a conformation with a global energy lower than the established record after several successive perturbation cycles, the *global patience*.

The last problem of this algorithm is the data transfers between the Central Processing Unit (CPU) and the Graphics Processing Unit (GPU) who slow down the optimization. To mitigate this, the algorithm groups execution of local optimization steps into blocks. During a execution of a block, every calculation are performed on GPU. The retrieval of energy values to the CPU only occurs at the end of the block. This technique helps to avoid a bottlenecks between the GPU and CPU.

To comprehend more clearly ours algorithm, you can see the diagram pipeline in the figure 6.

5.4 Complete Pipeline

Before the optimization phase, the coarse-gained model must be instantiated with starting spatial coordinates for its virtual beads. The molecule is generated as a simple linear chain, with adjacent beads separated by an equilibrium bond distance. This equilibrium bond distance was obtained from statistical analyse. We retrieved all RNA with a resolution inferior at 1.0 Å from the PDB and we extract every inter-distance from one atom particulary (eg : C3' or C4') and we used the mean. With this phase, the strucutre is a linear, considering neutral, and can be used at a starting point for the optimization phase.

After the optimization phase, we obtain a PDB file with only the coordinate of the reference atom. To passing to a coarse-gained representation to a full-atom representation, we passed the strucuture into a software ARENA [17]. The software will maps ideal nucleobase and sugar-phosphate templates onto the optimized strucure obtained.

Finally after the full-atom reconstruction, we used to tools AMBER14[6] force fiel within the OpenMM [16] simulation framework to ensure strict thermodynamic realism and to resolve any residual steric clashes.

At the end of this pipeline, the result is a highly refined, all-atom structural model and exported into standard structural biology formats.

5.5 Different Applications

Beyond the prediction of RNA three-dimensional structures, the proposed algorithmic framework can be repurposed for dynamic structural analysis. Because the core optimization engine—driven by the Adam gradient descent—relies on a continuously differentiable objective function, the knowledge-based statistical potential can be substituted with a purely geometric metric, such as the Root-Mean-Square Deviation (RMSD) relative to a known experimental target. By minimizing this derivable distance metric instead of thermodynamic energy, the optimization algorithm will calculate gradients that guide the spatial coordinates toward the target state. Recording

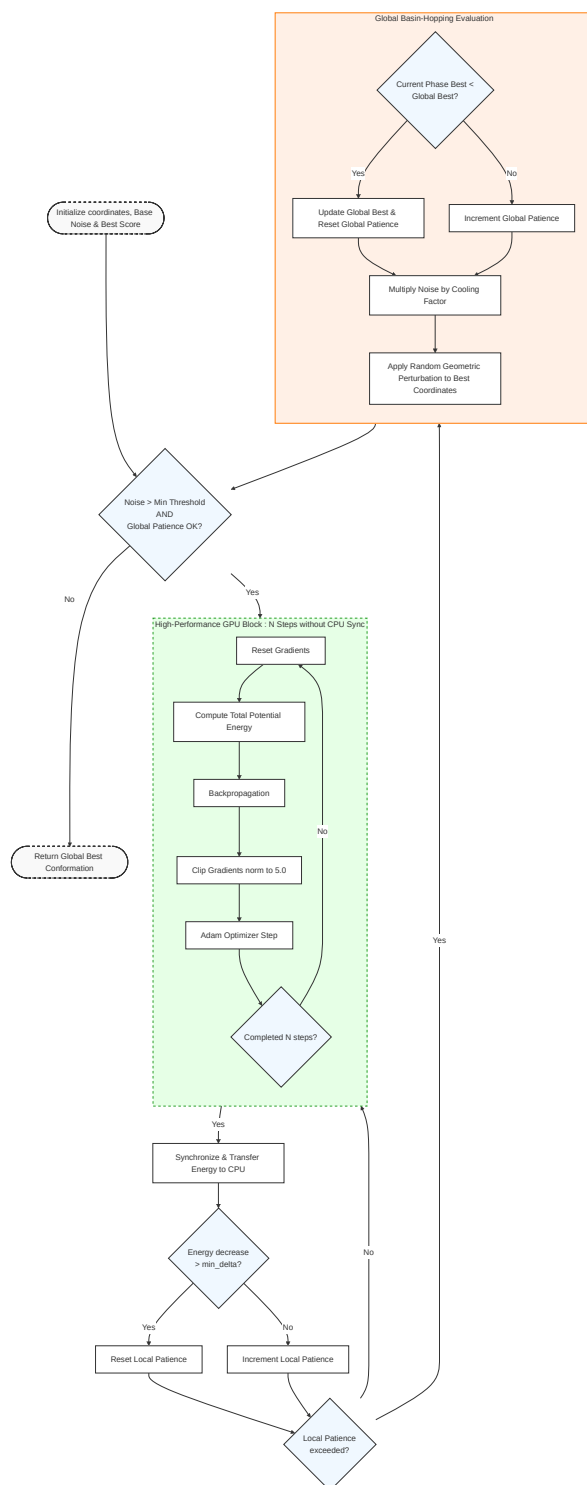


Figure 6: Overview of the combined local (Adam) and global (basin-hopping) optimization pipeline.

this stepwise convergence generates a continuous structural trajectory, effectively producing a computational "movie" of the simulated folding pathway.

Furthermore, this methodology can be extended to investigate complex RNA conformational dynamics. Instead of initializing the optimization algorithm from a linear chain, the coarse-grained model can be seeded with the coordinates of a natively folded state, while setting a different known conformation of the exact same RNA as the RMSD target. So the optimization algorithm will produce the structural transition between the two topologies. Consequently, the framework can be utilized to simulate and observe conformational switches

6 Results

6.1 Interpolation results

6.2 Comparaison between original and predicted structures

6.3 Comparatives tables

6.4 Line chart of score function for folding trajectory

6.5 Internet platform for RNA folding

7 Discussion and Perspectives

8 Conclusion

Glossary

D | **M** | **P** | **R**

D

DNA DesoxyriboNucleic Acid. [1](#),

M

mmCIF macromolecular Crystallographic Information File. [5](#),

P

PDB Protein Data Bank. [5](#),

R

RASP Ribonucleic Acids Statistical Potential.

RNA RiboNucleic Acid. [1](#),

Articles

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List of Figures

1	A diagram illustrating the processes of DNA transcription into RNA and RNA translation into proteins. Source : [1]	1
2	A diagram illustrating the 1D-structure of RNA and nucleotid composition. Source : [3]	2
3	A diagram illustrating different structural motifs . Source : [10]	3
4	The three different level of representation for the same RNA (PDB ID : 3DIQ) .	3
5	Line 808 from the pdb file from the pdb id 1J8G [8]	6
6	Overview of the combined local (Adam) and global (basin-hopping) optimization pipeline.	10

List of Tables

1	All keywords founded in a first part of a PDB files	5
2	All keywords founded in a second part of a PDB files	5
3	All keywords found in the coordinate section of a PDB file	6